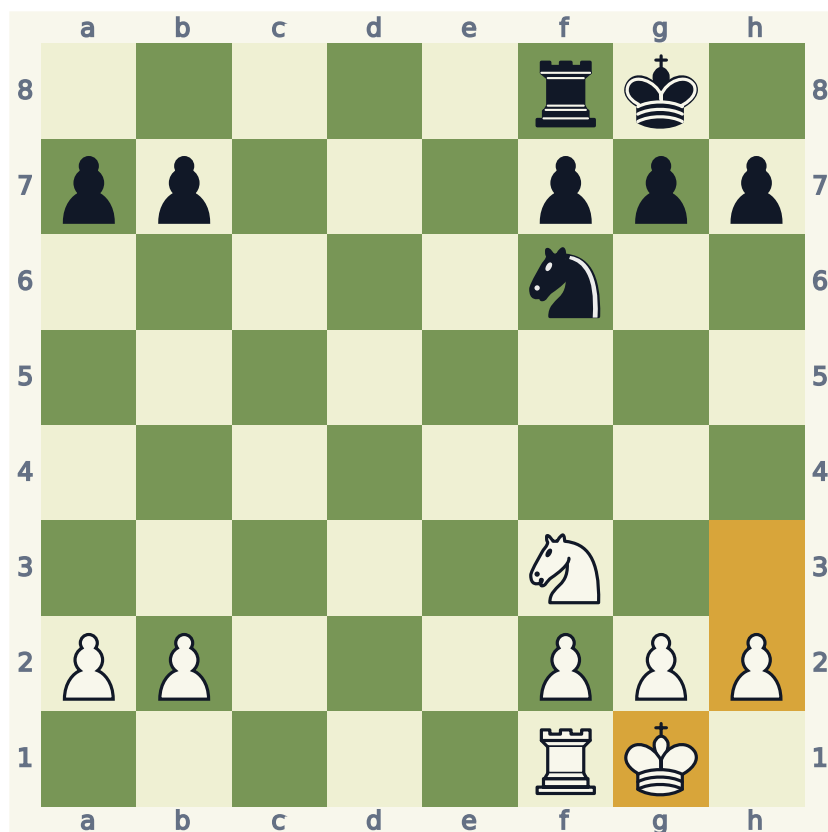


King safety and pawn cover

A shelter is valuable only with defenders and time.

King safety depends on pawn cover, open lines, nearby defenders and the number of attackers that can arrive. A pawn move may create an escape square or stop a piece, but it also leaves squares behind. Judge the whole position before trading cover for activity or launching a pawn storm.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- Both kings have three shelter pawns.
- h3 creates h2 as a potential escape square.
- No queens or bishops are present, so diagonal weaknesses are less immediately dangerous.

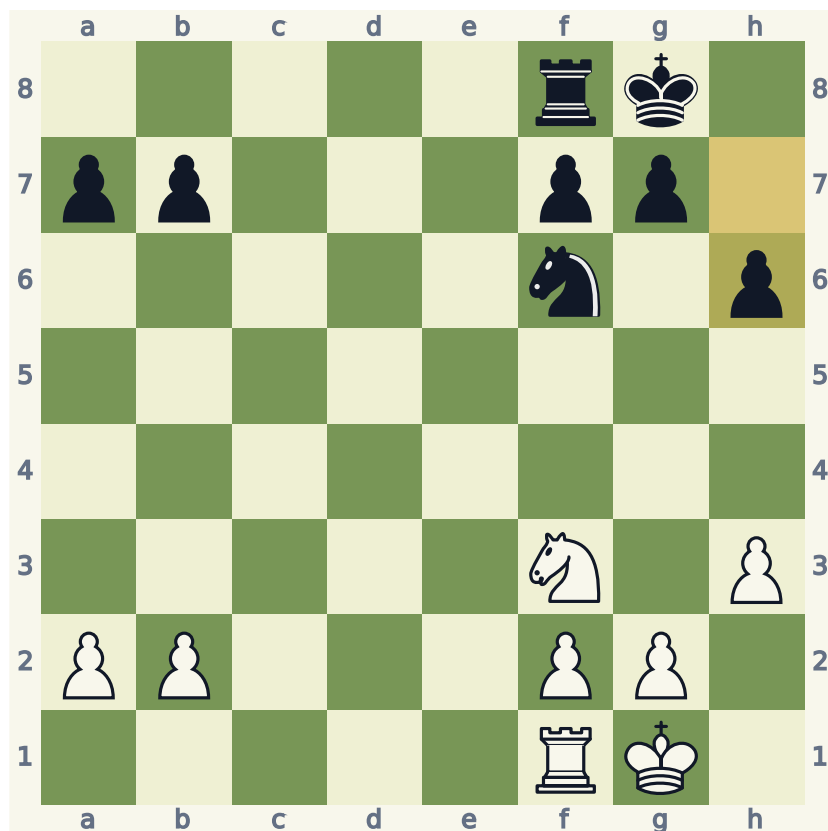
REMEMBER

- Count attackers, defenders and open lines.
- Verify that every escape square is safe.
- A pawn storm also changes your own shelter.

Follow the logic

1. h3 h6

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



h3

Create room and control g4. The move has identifiable benefits, but it also spends a tempo.

...h6

Black makes the same kind of move. Symmetry does not prove that either move was the most urgent one.

Reassess

In this reduced position centralizing the king may soon matter more than preserving a full middlegame shelter.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

The opponent should look for checks and access to newly weakened squares. In a fuller position, a bishop sacrifice or an opened file can radically change the safety of the same pawn formation.

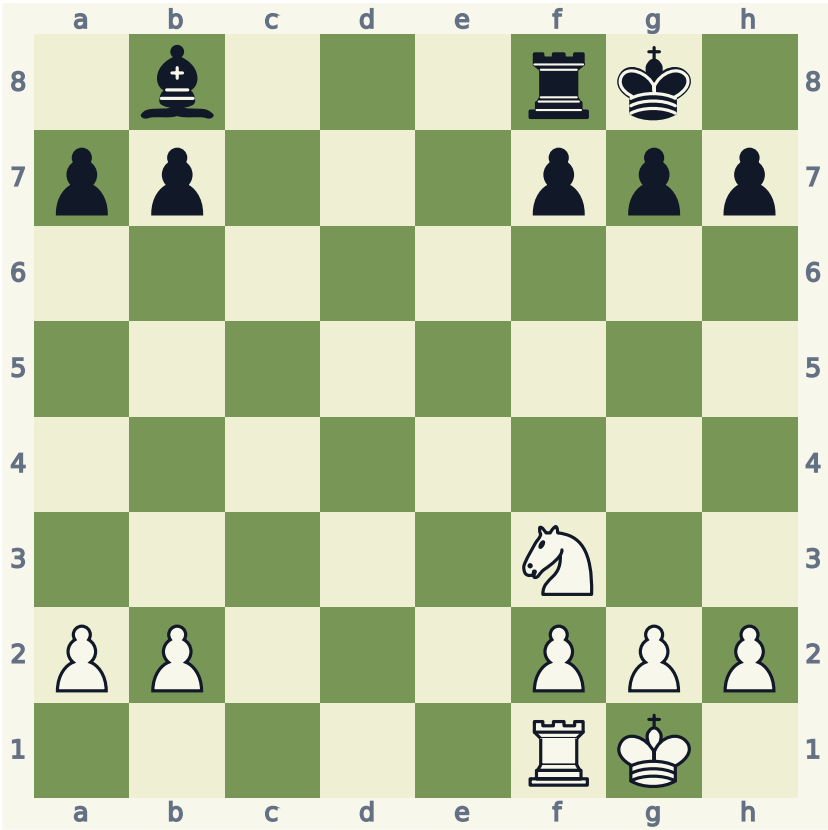
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

An escape square must be safe from enemy control. Moving h2-h3 does not solve a back-rank problem if an enemy bishop or rook controls h2. Check the square, not just the empty space.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Does h3 create a safe escape square on h2 here?
- 2. Trace the black bishop's diagonal.
- 3. What should White consider before relying on a back-rank defense?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

If White had a pawn on g3, would the same bishop still control h2?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 1b3rk1/pp3ppp/8/8/5N2/PP3PPP/5RK1 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. No. h2 becomes empty, but it is controlled by the bishop on b8. The white king cannot legally move into that attack.
2. The diagonal is b8-c7-d6-e5-f4-g3-h2. All intermediate squares are clear. This is why counting empty adjacent squares is insufficient.
3. White must remove or block the bishop's control, create a different safe square, or prevent a rook invasion by active defense. The exact move depends on threats and available tempi.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. h3 Re8

Changed feature: No. The pawn on g3 blocks the diagonal and is itself attacked. That may change the escape-square calculation, but the pawn's safety must then be checked.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

In three castled positions, mark every legal king escape square and the enemy line that would remove it.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 01, 09, 20. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.